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# Working in Teams

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- 1. Team Success**
  - 2. Team Goals and Activity**
  - 3. Social Loafing**
  - 4. Roles and Behaviors**
  - 5. Communication**
  - 6. Conflict**
  - 7. Decision-Making**

# Why Teams?

- What teams have you been a part of?
- Teams differ from groups, in that they have applied functions. Your role on a team relates to the function you provide to it.
- Does your team have clearly defined roles? What function are you performing?
- *Organizations are shifting away from individual work performed in hierarchical structures and toward team-based operations. (Levi, 14)*



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## Four Conditions for Team Success:

1. The team must have the right people to perform the task. (Team Composition)
2. The task must be suitable for teamwork. (Task Characteristics)
3. The team must combine its resources effectively to complete the task. (Group Process)
4. The organization must provide a supportive context for the team. (Organizational Context)

The right people  
**Team Composition**

Suitable for Teamwork  
**Task Characteristics**

Combine Resources  
**Group Process**

Supportive Context  
**Organizational Context**

When were you on a team that was not successful. Which of the

met?



# Team Composition

- Do team members have the needed **knowledge, skills, and abilities**?
- If everyone on the team is highly talented at the technical tasks, **isn't success guaranteed?** Why or why not?
- Besides talent, successful teams will include members who have **interpersonal skills, problem-solving skills, and teamwork skills**. (And companies/organizations will look for this.)



# When Are Teams Appropriate for the Task?

- The work contains at least some skilled activities.
- The team can form a meaningful unit within the organization, with clearly defined input and output and stable boundaries.
- Valid performance evaluation systems exist for both the team and its members.
- Timely feedback is possible.
- The team is capable of measuring and controlling the important variances in the workflow.
- The tasks are highly interdependent so members must work together.

Have you ever been on a team where the task was not suitable for teamwork?



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## Team Goals:

- Serve as a **standard** that can be used to evaluate performance
- **Motivate** team members by encouraging their involvement in the task
- Provide a criterion for **evaluating** whether certain actions and decisions are appropriate
- Serve as a way to inform outside groups about the team and **establish a relationship** with them
- Determine when team members should be **rewarded** or punished for their performance

Have you ever been on a team **without clearly defined goals**? What are the current goals for your



# Stages of Teamwork:

| Stage:     | Activity:                                                  |
|------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Forming    | Orientation: members getting to know one another           |
| Storming   | Conflict: disagreement about roles and procedures          |
| Norming    | Structure: establishment of rules and social relationships |
| Performing | Work: focus on completing the task                         |
| Adjourning | Dissolution: completion of task and end of the group       |

# The Impact of Written Goals on Long-term Success



- **Background:** A study conducted on Harvard MBA students analyzed the effect of goal-setting on future success.
- **Methodology:**
  - Participants: Graduates of Harvard's MBA program.
  - Duration: Follow-up conducted ten years post-graduation.
  - Criteria: Comparison between students with written goals and those without.
- **Key Findings:**
  - Written Goals: Only 3% had written goals and plans.
  - Mental Notes: 13% had goals but they were not in writing.
  - No Goals: 84% had no specific goals.
- **Results:**
  - The 3% with written goals were earning, on average, ten times as much as the other 97% combined.
  - A significant correlation found between clearly defined, written goals and increased net worth over time.
- **Conclusion:** The act of writing down specific goals provides clarity and a strong sense of direction, significantly impacting long-term success and financial outcomes.

# Creating SMART goals



**S**pecific

**M**easurable

**A**ttainable

**R**ealistic

**T**imely (and

**T**angible)

# Creating **specific** goals

A **specific** goal has a much greater chance of being accomplished than a general goal.

A general goal would be, "Implement common core state standards." But a specific goal would say, "Implement one standard every six weeks, and have two formative and one summative assessment with it."

# Creating measurable goals

Establish concrete criteria for measuring progress toward the attainment of each goal you set.

When you measure your progress, you stay on track, reach your target dates, and experience the exhilaration of achievement that spurs you on to continued effort required to reach your goal.

# Creating attainable goals

When you identify goals that are most important to you, you begin to figure out ways you can make them come true.

You develop the attitudes, abilities, skills, and financial capacity to reach them. You begin seeing previously overlooked opportunities to bring yourself closer to the achievement of your goals.



# Creating realistic goals

To be realistic, a goal must represent an objective toward which you are both *willing* and *able* to work.

A high goal is frequently easier to reach than a low one because a low goal exerts low motivational force. Some of the hardest jobs you ever accomplished actually seem easy simply because they were a labor of love.

# Creating **timely** goals

A goal should be grounded within a time frame. With no time frame tied to it, there is no sense of urgency.

When do you want to accomplish your goal? “Someday” won't work.

But if you anchor it within a timeframe (“by May 1<sup>st</sup>”), then you have already set your unconscious mind into motion to begin working on the goal.

# SMART Goals

**SPECIFIC**

**MEASURABLE**

**ACHIEVABLE**

**RELEVANT**

**TIME-BOUNDED**

**SMART GOALS**

SMART  
GOALS

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GOALS

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GOALS

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1. Team Success
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  - 3. Social Loafing**
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## Social Loafing: When Someone is Slacking Off

When an individual works in a team rather than alone, there is a potential reduction of contribution. This can happen for a variety of reasons:

- The “free rider”: when one believes that, regardless of their individual effort, they will receive a fair share of the team’s reward
- The “sucker effect”: when a high performer slacks off, in order to not feel taken advantage of by lower performing team members





Free Rider





**Sucker Effect**



## Why Aren't They Pulling Their Weight?

- If the team's goal is merely a collection of individual tasks requiring no coordination, this can lead to a lack of motivation, which causes social loafing.
- Individual performance can easily be hidden in a team's effort, leading to social loafing, as one no longer cares about what others think about their performance.
- People tend to overestimate their contributions to a team's effort, leading to social loafing, as they feel they've already "done their part".





## Overcoming Social Loafing

- Perform truly interdependent tasks.
- Increase team motivation.
- Clarify team roles.
- Make each individual's participation observable and measurable.

When have you been part of a team with a strong sense of identity and high motivation, which prevents social loafing?

Sports teams are very good at avoiding social loafing. Why?



# Translation

- Project manager: Are you done with the edit API?
- Developer: Yes, I left it at home.
- **Translation**
- Developer: I haven't done squat.



# Translation

- Project manager: Are you done with field validators?
- Developer: Yes, I just forgot to push.
- **Translation**
- Developer: I haven't done squat.



# Translation

- Project manager: Are you done with the image processing?
- Developer: Yes, it's on my USB stick at home.
- **Translation**
- Developer: I haven't done squat.



# Solution

- Don't give excuses.
- Simply show your work.
- If you don't show your work, you might as well have not done it (but you probably didn't anyway).

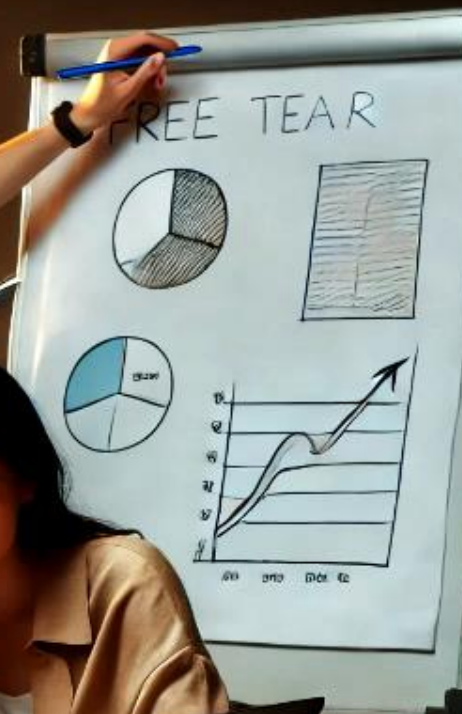


## Another Solution

- There MUST always be a due date/time for tasks.
- In this way a team member knows when something is due.



# Social Loafers



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1. Team Success
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## Team Roles

*Roles are one of the basic building blocks of successful teams performance. A role is a set of behaviours typical of people in certain social context. Roles within a team are similar to roles in a play: They describe what people are supposed to do and how their parts relate to what others in the team are doing. (Levi, 71)*

**Role Ambiguity** and **Role Conflict** are sources of relational stress within a team which interfere with both team motivation and accomplishing tasks. These tend to worsen as a project gets closer to the deadline. How would you define each?

# The Two Types of Team Behaviors

- Task Behaviors focus on the team's performance goal
  - Examples: information sharing and back-up assistance
- Social Behaviors focus on maintaining emotional balance and healthy team relationships
  - Examples: recognition and encouragement

Both are crucial for accomplishing team goals. It can be very easy for project-oriented teams to ignore the necessity and importance of the relational aspects of teamwork that lead to higher team performance.



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# Communication: The Foundation of Everything

Good communication skills:

- foster trust
- establish appropriate team norms
- develops a collaborative and creative climate

These benefits must be maintained over time through continued effort. They are not merely attained once, then last forever. (What happens to a friendship when two people stop communicating over a long period of time?)

Communication is important for both the task-oriented behaviors and social-oriented behaviors: it will maximize productivity as well as foster team cohesion. Both are important for team success.



# Bad Communication Habits

Teams have the potential to make better decisions than individuals. Why?

However, there also exists the potential for dysfunction in how information is processed:

- Focusing on common information shared by all instead of considering specialized, unique information known by few.
- Seeking only information that confirms pre-existing beliefs and attitudes and ignoring information that is perceived as a threat to currently held beliefs (a.k.a “Confirmation Bias”: You tend to find only what you expect to see).
- Processing information only in terms of False Dichotomies: the tendency to view options only in terms of two opposing extremes, when, in reality, many possibilities exist.



# Positive vs. Negative Communication Patterns

- Evaluation vs. Description
- Control vs. Problem Orientation
- Deception vs. Honesty
- Neutrality vs. Empathy





## How to Have a Good Team Meeting:

- Only have a meeting when there is no other alternative.
- Put the purpose of the meeting in writing and share it with everyone before the meeting (a.k.a. Agenda).
- Start and end the meeting on time. It demonstrates competency and shows respect.
- Minimize disruptive behaviors (like when one person dominates the conversation) and verbally affirm acceptable behavior. Deal with persistent problems privately.
- Put in writing a summary of important discussion and significant decisions that were made for everyone to reference (a.k.a. Minutes).

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## Misconceptions about Conflict:

- All conflict is bad and should be avoided.
- All conflict is caused by misunderstandings amongst team members.
- All conflict can be resolved to everyone's satisfaction.



**The Reality:** Conflict is inevitable. It is produced by change. It is often beneficial to the team's success.



## Healthy Conflict Arises from:

- Focusing on task issues
- Legitimate differences of opinion about the task
- Differences in values and perspectives
- Different expectations about the impact of decisions



## Unhealthy Conflict Arises from:

- Competition over power, rewards, and resources
- Conflict between individual and team goals
- Poorly run team meetings
- Personal grudges from the past
- Faulty communication



## Approaches to Conflict Resolution:

- Collaborating: working together to intentionally solve a problem
- Compromising: bargaining when a win-win isn't possible
- Accommodating: smoothing out a situation by giving up on a position
- Forcing: compelling a zero-sum solution in a win-lose situation
- Avoiding: withdraw or delay dealing with an issue

Each approach has pros and cons. Can you figure out what they are?



## Steps for Negotiating a Solution:

- Separate the people from the problem
- Focus on shared interests
- Develop many options to be used as a solution
- Evaluate the options using objective criteria
- Keep trying

When have you successfully negotiated a solution to a team conflict?

1. Team Success
2. Team Goals and Ac
3. Social Loafing
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# The Decision-Making Spectrum

- **Leader-Oriented:** leader decides; leader assigns expert to decide; leader consults team then decides
- **Team-Oriented:** objective mathematical technique; structured process; pure democracy, where majority rules
- **Full Consensus:** all members participate until agreement on a decision

Can you name the advantages and disadvantages of each decision making approach?



## Determining the Right Approach:

- Is a high-quality decision required?
- Does the team/individual have enough information to make a decision?
- Is the problem structured?
- Who will be tasked with implementing the decision?
- What is the social standing of the team leader?
- Do members agree on how team goals are attained?



# Guidelines If You're Going for a Full Consensus

- Avoid arguing for your own position without listening to the position of others.
- Do not change your position just to avoid conflict.
- Do not try to reach a quick agreement by using conflict-reduction approaches, such as voting or tossing a coin.
- Encourage others to explain their position so that you better understand any differences.
- Do not assume that someone must win and someone must lose when there is a disagreement.
- Discuss the underlying assumptions, listen carefully to one another, and encourage the participation of all members.
- Look for creative and collaborative solutions that allow both sides to win rather than compromises where each side only gets some of what it wants.



# Acknowledgment:

Group Dynamics for Teams, 5th ed. by Daniel Levi